

BlueCart Mobile Checkout: UX Research Findings

Prepared by the BlueCart UX Research Team | Q2 2026

Executive Summary

BlueCart's mobile checkout flow converts at 62%, roughly eight points below the e-commerce app benchmark for our category. This study set out to understand where shoppers hesitate, abandon, or experience friction between adding an item to their cart and completing payment. We identified four findings that, taken together, account for the majority of observed drop-off, and we recommend four targeted changes that can be tested against a control in the next release cycle.

Methodology

We conducted moderated, task-based usability sessions with 12 participants over a two-week period in April 2026. Participants were recruited through an external panel and screened for two criteria: they had completed at least one mobile purchase from a general-merchandise retailer in the prior 30 days, and they were not current BlueCart power users. The sample skewed slightly toward women (7 of 12) and ranged in age from 24 to 58.

Each 45-minute session was conducted remotely via Zoom with screen sharing from the participant's personal device. Participants completed three core tasks on a staging build of the BlueCart iOS and Android apps: adding two items to cart from a product listing, applying a promotional code, and completing checkout using a saved payment method. Sessions were recorded with consent, and we used a think-aloud protocol throughout. Analysis followed an affinity-mapping approach across two reviewers, with findings prioritized by frequency (how many of the 12 participants experienced the issue) and severity (whether the issue blocked task completion).

Findings

Finding 1: Shipping cost surprise drives late-stage abandonment

Nine of twelve participants reacted negatively when shipping costs first appeared on the payment screen. Several paused, scrolled back to the cart to verify subtotal, or expressed frustration that the total had changed. Three participants explicitly said they would have abandoned the purchase in real life. The current flow surfaces shipping only after the user enters an address, which is two screens deep into checkout.

“Wait, where did that come from? I thought I was paying twenty-eight dollars, not thirty-five. If I were doing this at home I'd just close the app and look somewhere else.”
— P04, 31, occasional shopper

Finding 2: Promo code field is hidden and easily missed

The “Have a promo code?” link is rendered as a small text link beneath the order summary. Seven of twelve participants did not notice it on first pass, and four had to be prompted before they found it. Two participants assumed the app did not support promo

codes at all and continued without applying the code we had given them as part of the task.

“Honestly, I just figured this app didn’t do coupons. I scrolled right past it twice. It looks like a footer disclaimer, not a button.” — P09, 44, frequent shopper

Finding 3: Guest checkout is buried behind an account prompt

First-time users are presented with a sign-in screen before they can proceed to payment, with the guest-checkout option appearing as a low-contrast secondary button below the fold on smaller devices. Five of the eight participants who tested the new-user flow attempted to back out of checkout before locating the guest option. The friction was most pronounced on devices with screen heights under 6 inches.

“I’m just trying to buy one thing. I don’t want to make an account, remember another password, all that. Why is this in my way?” — P02, 27, occasional shopper

Finding 4: Order review screen creates uncertainty about final charge

On the final review screen, taxes are displayed as a separate line item that updates after the user taps “Place Order,” causing a brief flash where the total changes. Six participants noticed this and three explicitly questioned whether they had been charged the amount they expected. Two participants tapped “Place Order” a second time, worried the first tap had not registered, raising the risk of duplicate-order support tickets.

“Did it go through? The number jumped right when I tapped it. I have no idea what I just paid. I’d be checking my email right now to make sure I wasn’t double-charged.” — P11, 38, frequent shopper

Recommendations

We recommend the following four changes for the next release. Each maps to one of the findings above and can be A/B tested independently against the current production flow.

1. **Surface shipping estimates in the cart.** Display an estimated shipping cost based on the user’s stored or detected location before they enter checkout. This eliminates the late-stage surprise documented in Finding 1.
2. **Promote the promo code field to a visible input.** Replace the text link with a labeled input field directly within the order summary, expanded by default. Track redemption rate as the primary metric.
3. **Lead with guest checkout for new users.** Make guest checkout the primary call-to-action on the sign-in screen and demote account creation to a post-purchase prompt. Pair with an offer to save details after the order is placed.
4. **Lock the final total before the Place Order tap.** Calculate and display taxes on the review screen before the user taps Place Order, so the displayed total is the charged total. Add a clear confirmation state to prevent duplicate taps.

Next Steps

The recommendations above are sequenced for a 6-week implementation window. We propose running the shipping-estimate and guest-checkout experiments first, as they target the highest-frequency drop-off points. Full session recordings, the affinity map, and participant demographics are available in the research repository.